

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN AZERBAIJAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Azerbaijan is among the hardest places in this series to oppose a project from within, and there is no community victory to point to. It is a wealthy, tightly controlled petro-state on the Caspian Sea, where the state oil company is the backbone of the economy and is expanding fossil-fuel production, and where independent civil society has been crushed: rights groups count hundreds of political prisoners, including environmental defenders jailed on charges international observers call bogus, and organisations set up to promote environmental justice have been forced to close before they could begin. When villagers in one region protested a **toxic-waste pond for a gold mine**, they were met with rubber bullets and tear gas, several were arrested, and their village was locked down for weeks. This guide will not pretend that a community inside Azerbaijan can safely and openly stop a destructive project; it cannot, and to suggest otherwise would put people in prison. But the same petro-state hungers for international legitimacy — hosting global summits, courting a modern and even green image, partnering with foreign oil companies and investors — and that hunger is its great vulnerability.

Those who would resist cannot do so safely inside the country, but a petro-state that craves the world's approval is vulnerable from without, and the tools are real. The **reputational lever** — the gap between the polished image and the repressive, fossil-fuelled reality — is the sharpest: a regime that hosts global climate summits and courts a green image cannot easily silence the exposure of its crackdowns, as global scrutiny of its jailing of defenders and its fossil expansion showed when it hosted the world's climate summit. The **foreign corporate partners and financiers** behind the oil and the mines operate under **standards and reputations** a case can hold them to. The **international human-rights, climate, and environmental bodies** can scrutinise the regime and be petitioned from outside. The **exile and international civil-society networks** carry the case and the testimony where those inside cannot speak. And **rigorous documentation** grounds it all. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Opposition inside Azerbaijan is dangerous: defenders and journalists are jailed on fabricated charges, protesters are fired on, villages are locked down, and the honest record is one of protests crushed and organisations shut, not of anyone stopping a project from within. The regime is wealthy, entrenched, and unafraid to repress. And the reputational lever pressures but does not command — it exposes and constrains rather than compels. So the work must be external, documentary, coalition-led, and above all protective of everyone inside — never exposing a name, never relying on domestic action — and the honest prize is scrutiny, exposure, and pressure on the partners and the reputation, not a project stopped from within.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely resist inside a state that jails environmental defenders, and you must never ask anyone to. What resisters can do is carry the fight to the one place a legitimacy-hungry petro-state is genuinely vulnerable — its reputation and its foreign partners — from outside: document the harm and the repression, expose the gap between the image and the reality, hold the foreign partners to their standards, petition the international bodies, and let exile and international voices speak, while protecting everyone inside absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Azerbaijan is one of the most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win by domestic protest — protest here is crushed, and there is no community victory to cite. It is an external, reputational, coalition-led effort whose realistic prize is exposure and pressure, not a stop. Enter it understanding that no project contested is worth a person imprisoned, and that the safety of everyone inside comes before every other consideration.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with an entrenched regime and its state oil company, in a closed system where independent civil society is crushed and the courts are captured. The decisions resisters can reach are therefore external — taken by the **foreign oil companies, investors, and financiers** who partner with the state and answer to their own standards, and in the **international human-rights, climate, and environmental bodies** whose scrutiny a legitimacy-hungry regime cannot ignore. The **exile and international networks** are the ones who can safely reach them.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A project advances by the regime's decision and its foreign partnerships; there is no safe domestic permit hearing to contest. Resisters enter where the outside world touches the harm: the foreign partner's standards and reputation, the international body's mandate, the global scrutiny that follows the regime's bids for legitimacy. Each is a point of leverage reached from outside — and the moment the regime seeks the world's approval is the moment it is most exposed.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the partners: which foreign companies, investors, and financiers stand behind the oil and the mines, and what environmental, human-rights, and climate standards they answer to. Follow the legitimacy: which summits, image campaigns, and international bids the regime is pursuing, and where its record contradicts them. The leverage lies in the foreign partners' standards and the gap between the regime's image and its reality.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is captured and unfree. The watchers resisters can engage are external: the international human-rights, climate, and environmental bodies, the foreign partners' own compliance and reputational systems, the investigative and press networks, and the exile and international civil society. These are the institutions a case is built to reach — safely, from outside.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Azerbaijani effort yields a domestic "win," and honesty requires saying so — the record is protests crushed and defenders jailed. What the external tools realistically deliver is exposure and pressure: a foreign partner's standards invoked, an international body's scrutiny summoned, the reputational gap widened when the regime courts the world. The single most decisive move is **rigorous, safely-gathered documentation of the harm and the repression**, because every external lever — the partners, the bodies, the reputational exposure — responds to credible evidence, and because the regime's image is most vulnerable precisely when the facts are undeniable. Nothing here is fast or certain, and no project is likely to be stopped from

within. But a petro-state that craves legitimacy can be made to answer for its record before the world it courts.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the fossil expansion, the mine's poison, the fouled air and water. **Who abroad is tied to it?** — the foreign oil company, investor, or financier, and the standards they answer to. **Which international body's mandate does it touch?** — the human-rights, climate, or environmental mechanism. **Where is the regime seeking legitimacy?** — the summit, the image campaign, the international bid where its record can be exposed. **How is everyone inside kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping all work external and exposing no one. Pick the harm where a foreign partner or an international body offers the clearest external handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, all gathered safely and from outside where possible. **Layer one: the harm and the repression** — the project's damage, and the crackdown that met any who questioned it, documented through published sources, satellite data, and testimony channelled safely. **Layer two: the partner and the standard** — which foreign company or financier is tied to the harm, and which of their standards, and which international body's mandate, it offends. **Layer three: the reputation and the protection** — where the regime's record contradicts its image, and the absolute rule that no name inside is exposed and all testimony is shielded. A case built on published documentation and shielded testimony — carried by exile and international voices — is one that reaches the levers without endangering anyone inside.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm-and-repression record**: the project's impact, the arrests and lockdowns, the jailed defenders, documented through published and international sources. Gather the **partner record**: the foreign companies, investors, and financiers, and the environmental, human-rights, and climate standards they answer to. Gather the **legitimacy record**: the summits, image campaigns, and international bids where the regime's record can be held up against its claims. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm every source is safely obtained, no name inside is exposed, and all testimony is shielded through trusted networks.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE EXILE AND INTERNATIONAL COALITION

The coalition here is external, because it must be. Build it from the **exile Azerbaijani networks and diaspora**, who can speak where those inside cannot; the **international human-rights, environmental, and climate organisations** that scrutinise the regime; the **investigative and press networks** that expose it; and the **campaigners who reach the foreign partners and financiers**. Where a defender is already imprisoned and publicly championed, take the lead of those defending them. Build carefully, protect every source and identity, and never in a way that draws in or exposes anyone inside the country.

STEP 4: FOREIGN-PARTNER, INTERNATIONAL & REPUTATIONAL LEVERS — CONTESTING THE HARM FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are external, they pressure rather than command, and no domestic action is safe.

The Reputational Lever

The sharpest lever is the **gap between the regime's polished image and its repressive, fossil-fuelled reality**. A petro-state that hosts summits and courts a green image is vulnerable to the exposure of its crackdowns and its expansion — and most vulnerable precisely when it seeks the world's approval. Widen that gap with documented facts, carried by international voices.

The Foreign Partners and Financiers

The **foreign oil companies, investors, and financiers** behind the harm operate under **environmental, human-rights, and climate standards and reputations** a case can hold them to. Press them, from outside, on whether the project meets the commitments they answer to — a pressure the regime itself cannot silence.

The International Bodies

The **international human-rights, climate, and environmental bodies** can be petitioned to scrutinise the regime's record and the specific harm. Pursued together — the reputational lever, the foreign partners, and the international bodies — these external levers contest the harm and press for accountability, while every person inside is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case to each audience. **For the foreign partners and financiers**: here is a project that fails the standards you answer to, and here is the reputational cost of being tied to it. **For the international bodies**: here is a documented harm and a documented crackdown your mandate reaches. **For the global public and the summit-watchers**: here is the gap between the image the regime sells and the reality it jails people to hide. **For the exile and international networks**: here is the documented case to carry where those inside cannot. **The golden rule**: keep everything external, argue the standards and the reputation, and protect every name inside absolutely — that is what makes the fight both effective and safe.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media is central, because the reputational lever lives in it. Frame the story around the **gap between image and reality**: a petro-state courting the world's approval while jailing defenders and expanding fossil fuels. Time it to the regime's own bids for legitimacy — the summits, the image campaigns — when the world is watching and the contradiction is sharpest. Carry it through international outlets, the investigative networks, and the diaspora. A few cautions govern everything: never expose a name inside; rely on published documentation and shielded testimony; keep it factual and undeniable; and let the contradiction between the image and the record carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message external, documentary, and absolutely protective of anyone inside.

8A — To a foreign oil company or investor: set out the harm and ask how the project meets the environmental, human-rights, and climate standards the company answers to.

8B — To a financier: present the evidence and ask how the financing meets the institution's commitments.

8C — To an international human-rights body: document the harm and the crackdown, and request scrutiny — with all names shielded.

8D — To an international climate or environmental body: set out the fossil expansion and its cost, and ask for attention.

8E — To investigative or press networks: offer the documented image-versus-reality case, timed to the regime's bids for legitimacy.

8F — To the exile and diaspora networks: share the case and ask for amplification and safe testimony channels.

8G — To a summit or international forum: raise the regime's record against its claims, publicly and with evidence.

8H — To the international public: summarise the gap between the image and the reality, and ask for pressure — never exposing anyone inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the published documentation of the harm and any repression; identify the foreign partner or financier tied to it; write the one-page image-versus-reality case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the foreign partners' standards, the international bodies, and the reputational exposure timed to a bid for legitimacy. **Emergency coalition-building:** reach the exile networks and the international organisations first — they can act safely from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and dangerous: a wealthy, entrenched regime, captured courts, crushed civil society. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not a stop, but exposure and pressure through the levers the closure cannot reach. Lean on the reputational lever, the foreign partners, and the international bodies, all pursued from outside. And accept the honest possibility of losing on any front — the regime may proceed regardless — while still widening the gap between its image and its record, and defending, always and above all, the people inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a petro-state, capture is the norm — the oil wealth, the mines, and the deals steered to enrich an entrenched elite. Respond only through the **external channels:** the foreign partners' standards, the international bodies, the investigative networks, the documented record carried by exile voices. Never through domestic action. **On safety and care:** this is the guide's most important note, and it governs everything. Azerbaijan jails environmental defenders and journalists, fires on protesters, and locks down villages. Keep the effort external, documentary, coalition-led, and above all protective of everyone inside. Never expose a name; rely on exile and international voices and published documentation; shield all testimony through trusted networks. Safety here is not caution at the expense of the cause — it is the first duty of the cause, because no project contested is worth a person imprisoned.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, all from outside. The documented harm and repression feed the reputational lever, the foreign-partner pressure, and the international-body petitions at once; the exile and international coalition organises alongside; the media widens the image-versus-reality gap throughout, timed to the regime's bids for legitimacy. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the published documentation and identify the foreign partners and bodies; **months two to six**, press the partners, petition the bodies, and time the reputational exposure to a summit or image campaign; **beyond**, sustain the external pressure and the accountability. The core discipline: external, documentary, reputational, and absolute in protecting everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Azerbaijan is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a project can be stopped from within, or that protest is safe, or that the courts are free — none of that is true, and the honest record is one of protests crushed and defenders jailed. What it claims is narrower and real: that a wealthy petro-state which hungers for the world's approval is genuinely vulnerable to its reputation; that its foreign partners and financiers answer to standards a case can invoke; that the international bodies can be petitioned; and that all of this can be carried, by exile and international networks, from outside — without ever exposing a single person inside. The levers are external, they pressure rather than command, and the prize is exposure and accountability, not a project halted from within. But for a repressive petro-state that courts the world, that external, reputational, protective work is not a lesser ambition — it is the only responsible and effective one, and the fight is being waged, and can be waged, from safer ground.